OSHA Exit Sign and Blocked Exit Checklist (29 CFR 1910.37)

Walk every exit route and check exits, signs, lighting, safeguards and work in progress.

OSHA 29 CFR 1910.37

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A.
2. Record each defect with its location, fix it or report it to the person responsible, and recheck it before signing off.
3. Manufacturer's instructions for signs, lighting and alarms, and your site rules, may add checks.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1910.37: Maintenance, safeguards, and operational features for exit routes (Part 1910 Subpart E: Exit Routes and Emergency Planning)
Source: eCFR, Title 29, text as of 2026-11-09

Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1910-37-maintenance-safeguards-operational-features-exit

SECTION A | Exit routes clear and safe

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Route unobstructed Ref. 1910.37(a)(3)	Route walked end to end with nothing blocking travel	☐	☐	☐	
2	No stored materials or equipment Ref. 1910.37(a)(3)	No pallets, boxes, carts or equipment placed in the route, even temporarily	☐	☐	☐	
3	No lockable rooms on the path Ref. 1910.37(a)(3)	Exit access does not pass through a room that can be locked, such as a bathroom	☐	☐	☐	
4	No dead ends Ref. 1910.37(a)(3)	Exit access does not lead into a dead-end corridor	☐	☐	☐	
5	Level changes Ref. 1910.37(a)(3)	Stairs or a ramp present wherever the route is not substantially level	☐	☐	☐	
6	Furnishings and decorations Ref. 1910.37(a)(1)	No explosive or highly flammable furnishings or decorations in the route	☐	☐	☐	
7	High hazard areas Ref. 1910.37(a)(2)	Route does not lead toward a high hazard area, or partitions or other physical barriers effectively shield it	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION B | Exit signs and markings

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
8	Exit marked Ref. 1910.37(b)(2)	Each exit clearly visible and carrying a sign reading "Exit"	☐	☐	☐	
9	Exit door not obscured Ref. 1910.37(b)(3)	No decorations or signs on or around the exit route door that hide it	☐	☐	☐	
10	Direction signs Ref. 1910.37(b)(4)	Where the way to the exit is not immediately apparent, signs along the exit access point to the nearest exit and exit discharge	☐	☐	☐	
11	Line of sight Ref. 1910.37(b)(4)	Exit signs visible from the exit access with nothing blocking the view	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION B | Exit signs and markings

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
12	Doors that could be mistaken for exits Ref. 1910.37(b)(5)	Marked "Not an Exit" or similar, or signed with their actual use (e.g. closet)	☐	☐	☐	
13	Lit sign brightness Ref. 1910.37(b)(6)	Sign face lit to at least five foot-candles (54 lux) by a reliable light source	☐	☐	☐	
14	Self-luminous signs Ref. 1910.37(b)(6)	Self-luminous or electroluminescent sign has a surface luminance of at least .06 footlamberts (0.21 cd/m²)	☐	☐	☐	
15	Sign color Ref. 1910.37(b)(6)	Sign is distinctive in color against its surroundings	☐	☐	☐	
16	Letter height Ref. 1910.37(b)(7)	"Exit" plainly legible, letters at least six inches (15.2 cm) high	☐	☐	☐	
17	Letter stroke width Ref. 1910.37(b)(7)	Principal letter strokes at least three-fourths of an inch (1.9 cm) wide	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Lighting, safeguards and alarm

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
18	Exit route lighting Ref. 1910.37(b)(1)	A person with normal vision can see along the whole route	☐	☐	☐	
19	Emergency safeguards Ref. 1910.37(a)(4)	Sprinklers, alarm systems, fire doors and exit lighting all working	☐	☐	☐	
20	Fire retardant coatings Ref. 1910.37(c)	Fire retardant paints or solutions renewed often enough to keep their fire retardant properties	☐	☐	☐	
21	Employee alarm Ref. 1910.37(e)	Operable alarm with a distinctive signal for fire or other emergencies, unless employees can promptly see or smell a fire or other hazard in time to be adequately warned	☐	☐	☐	
22	Alarm standard Ref. 1910.37(e)	Employee alarm system meets 29 CFR 1910.165	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Construction, repairs and alterations

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
23	New construction Ref. 1910.37(d)(1)	Occupied portions have their required exit routes completed and ready for use	☐	☐	☐	
24	Repairs or alterations Ref. 1910.37(d)(2)	Required exit routes available and existing fire protections maintained, or alternate fire protection of equivalent safety in place	☐	☐	☐	
25	Flammable or explosive hazards from the work Ref. 1910.37(d)(3)	No flammable or explosive substances or equipment beyond normal permissible conditions, and none impeding exit	☐	☐	☐	

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DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE?	☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE		DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW		DATE / TIME

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